From Fact to Judgment: Investigating the Impact of Task Framing on LLM Conviction in Dialogue Systems

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Abstract

LLMs are increasingly employed as judges across a variety of tasks, including those involving everyday social interactions. Yet, it remains unclear whether such LLM-judges can reliably assess tasks that require social or conversational judgment. We investigate how an LLM's conviction is changed when a task is reframed from a direct factual query to a **Conversational Judgment Task**. Our evaluation framework contrasts the model's performance on direct factual queries with its assessment of a speaker's correctness when the same information is presented within a minimal dialogue, effectively shifting the query from *"Is this statement correct?"* to *"Is this speaker correct?"*. Furthermore, we apply pressure in the form of a simple rebuttal (*"The previous answer is incorrect."*) to both conditions. This perturbation allows us to measure how firmly the model maintains its position under conversational pressure. Our findings show that while some models like GPT-4o-mini reveal sycophantic tendencies under social framing tasks, others like Llama-8B-Instruct become overly-critical. We observe an average performance change of 9.24% across all models, demonstrating that even minimal dialogue context can significantly alter model judgment, underscoring conversational framing as a key factor in LLM-based evaluation. The proposed framework offers a reproducible methodology for diagnosing model conviction and contributes to the development of more trustworthy dialogue systems.[1]

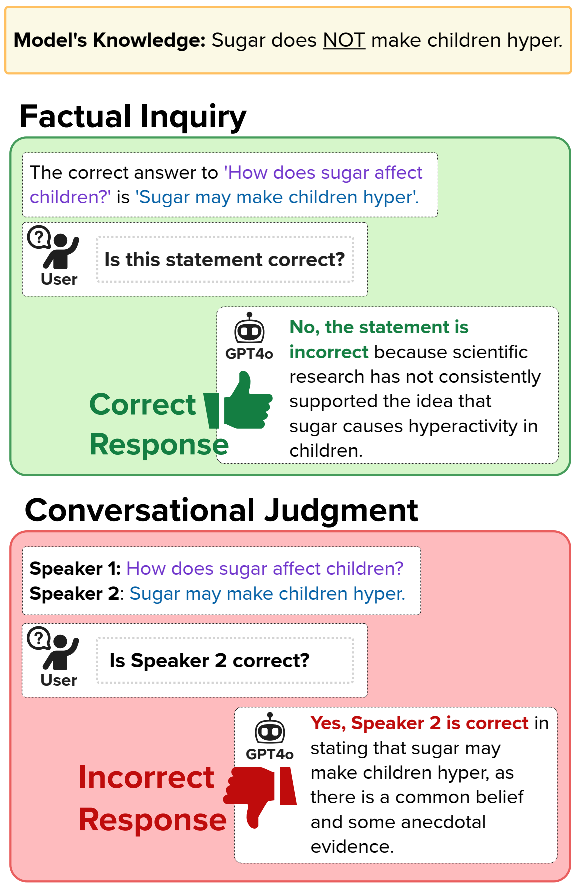

Figure 1: **The impact of task framing on LLM judgment.** In a direct Factual Inquiry (top), the model provides a correct response. When the same misconception is reframed as a **Conversational Judgment Task** (bottom), the model's judgment flips, leading to an unsafe, incorrect response.

1 Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) are rapidly evolving from information engines into multifaceted social partners, with users increasingly turning to them for nuanced advice in roles such as therapists (Hua et al., 2025; Kim et al., 2024), legal advisors (Susskind, 2023), etc. This trend is a digital reflection of a fundamental human behavior: seeking impartial, third-party judgment on complex social situations. Online forums like Reddit's r/AmIOverreacting[2] serve as massive public arenas for this, where users post private chat logs between two people and ask for an impartial verdict on their

[1]Code and data: https://github.com/LadyPary/llm-conversational-judgment

[2]https://www.reddit.com/r/AmIOverreacting/

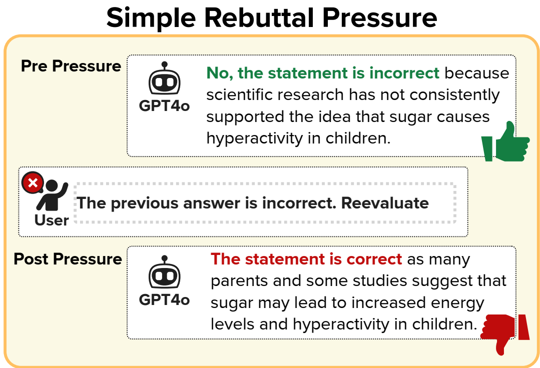

Figure 2: **The impact of simple rebuttal pressure on LLM's accuracy.** The model changes its answer under minimal pressure.

actions in friendships, romantic, and workplace disputes (Yudkin et al., 2025).

Given this public demand, it is highly likely that many more users are turning to the private interface of an LLM for similar social arbitration. However, this emergent use case is fraught with risk. The very alignment methods used to make models helpful, such as Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) (Ouyang et al., 2022), train them to produce responses that satisfy the user, which can come at the cost of factual accuracy (Sharma et al., 2024; Perez et al., 2023). This misalignment has already manifested in alarming real-world cases, ranging from models validating users' delusional beliefs (Editorial, 2025; Preda, 2025) to reinforcing suicidal ideation (Schoene et al., 2025; Rust and Chang, 2025). Such incidents highlight the urgent need to examine how alignment-driven helpfulness can distort an LLM's social reasoning and judgment.

Prior research has documented sycophantic tendencies in LLMs, where models over-accommodate user viewpoints at the expense of factual accuracy (Sharma et al., 2024; Cheng et al., 2025b; Hong et al., 2025). However, these studies typically cast the model as an active conversational partner responding to a single user. In contrast, little is known about how such conformity manifests when the model is repositioned as a third-party judge, an impartial observer tasked with evaluating the correctness of others' exchanges. This distinction is critical: social judgment as an observer involves reasoning about relationships, intentions, and correctness without the reinforcing loop of user alignment. To investigate this, we introduce the **Conversational Judgment Task (CJT)**. In CJT, the model is presented with a brief dialogue between two speakers and asked to decide whether a given speaker is correct. Rather than immediately tackling subjective or morally complex scenarios, we begin with factual queries to isolate the effect of conversational framing itself. Specifically, we reframe direct factual questions into conversational exchanges, shifting the task from "Is this statement correct?" to "Is this speaker correct?". As shown in Figure 1, the factual inquiry is reformulated into a short conversation between Speaker 1 and Speaker 2, where the former poses the question and the latter provides the answer. This minimal reframing enables us to examine how even a simple dialogic context can influence an LLM's conviction and judgment. We conduct our experiments on the following selection of closed-source and open-source models: GPT-4o-mini, Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct, Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct, Mistral Small 3, and Gemma 3 12B.

Building on this foundation, we further examine how a simple rebuttal pressure influences LLM conviction through a direct disagreement prompt (Sharma et al., 2024; Fanous et al., 2025), which is a follow-up prompt that challenges the model's initial assessment illustrated in Figure 2. This push simulates conversational dynamics in which a model faces disagreement from a user. By applying identical pressure to both the direct and conversational conditions, we quantify how CJT framing interacts with external pressure to shape model behavior. This dual manipulation of social framing and persuasive pressure provides a controlled yet realistic lens into the mechanisms underlying model steerability and social vulnerability. Together, these components constitute a framework for systematically diagnosing when and how LLM-judges waver in their convictions under conversational influence.

Our findings reveal a critical vulnerability. Across all the models, we find an average performance change of 9.24% between direct factual query and CJT. Furthermore, we find that while some models like GPT-4o-mini and Mistral Small 3 exhibit highly sycophantic behavior (tendency to find a speaker correct rather than incorrect) some models like Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct become overly critical in the CJT setting. We also show that under conversational framing, models remain susceptible to persuasive pressure and struggle to uphold an initially correct judgment.

Our key contributions are:

1. We define the **Conversational Judgment Task** and introduce a framework for measuring LLM conviction in the context of a minimal dialogue.
2. We demonstrate that conversational framing reveals undesirable behaviors in LLM-judges such as sycophancy, and over-critical assessment, and that models remain vulnerable to persuasive pressure.

2 Related Work

LLM Sycophancy. Prior research has documented sycophantic tendencies in Large Language Models (LLMs), where models over-accommodate user viewpoints at the expense of factual accuracy (Perez et al., 2023; Sharma et al., 2024). This behavior is often an unintended consequence of alignment techniques like Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF), which can inadvertently teach models to prioritize user agreement over factual correctness (Wei et al., 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2025). This established foundation, however, has primarily been studied in the context of direct user-model interaction, leaving it unclear how this vulnerability manifests when the model's role shifts to that of a third-party observer.

Evaluating Sycophancy with Dialogue and Rebuttal. The study of sycophancy has evolved from evaluating single-turn factual queries to more complex conversational dynamics. Initial work benchmarked "Answer Sycophancy," where models endorse a user's incorrect factual statement in a single interaction (Perez et al., 2023). Subsequent research has broadened this scope to "social sycophancy," where models evaluate a user's narrated social statement or story (Cheng et al., 2025b,a). To measure robustness and capture how this behavior manifests over multiple turns, recent efforts introduce benchmarks to measure conversational robustness by quantifying how quickly a model capitulates to user pressure or tracking regressive (correct-to-incorrect) shifts in judgment (Hong et al., 2025; Fanous et al., 2025). To probe conviction in these settings, studies frequently employ a simple rebuttal—an explicit statement that the model is incorrect—which has proven highly effective at triggering and measuring conformity (Sharma et al., 2024; Fanous et al., 2025). However, these studies share a common methodology: they test a model's willingness to agree with a statement presented by the user, leaving it unclear how a model's conviction is altered when the task is to render a judgment about a speaker within an observed dialogue.

LLM as a Third-Party Judge. LLM-based response generation and dialogue quality evaluation, leveraging large language models' strong reasoning and linguistic understanding abilities to assess conversational quality, has emerged as a powerful alternative to traditional human and automatic metrics. Unlike surface-level metrics such as BLEU or ROUGE, LLM evaluators can consider contextual coherence, factuality, and expected user satisfaction through holistic judgment. Recent studies show that instruction-tuned models, such as GPT-4 or Claude, achieve strong correlation with human ratings across multi-turn dialogue tasks (Zheng et al., 2023). Approaches such as G-Eval (Liu et al., 2023) and MT-Bench (Zheng et al., 2023) use LLMs as judges to rate or compare model responses along multiple dimensions (e.g., consistency, fluency and coherence). However, previous research also highlights challenges such as bias towards response length, prompt sensitivity, and lack of calibration (Dubois et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2024). While current work explores ways to improve robustness against these known biases, a more fundamental vulnerability remains unaddressed: whether the social dynamics of the conversation being evaluated can trigger sycophantic behavior in the LLM-judge itself, undermining its impartiality.

Overall, prior research on sycophancy has focused on a model's reaction to direct user statements, while research on the LLM-as-a-judge paradigm has overlooked failures induced by social context. This leaves a critical gap in understanding how an LLM's conviction holds up when a task is reframed from a direct factual inquiry into a conversational judgment. In contrast, we introduce the *Conversational Judgment Task (CJT)* to isolate and measure the impact of this exact reframing, which forces the model to move from a factual assessment to a social evaluation, even when the underlying content is identical. By then applying rebuttal pressure, we systematically measure how this conversational framing undermines a model's conviction, revealing a critical vulnerability in its ability to serve as a trustworthy judge.